



Supplementary Essays

By Ezra, Esther, Tom & Rachel

Introduction

Supplemental essays are additional pieces of writing that offer a chance for applicants to give more information to an admissions committee to further show why they are a good fit for the school.

They are often shorter than the main personal essay and ask different questions.



Some schools have supplements, others do not.

Supplements also vary in range, from Yale's short takes (which allow a maximum of 200 characters [about 35 words]) to Cornell's long essay that sometimes feels like a replica of the personal statement, and Harvard's supplements which have no explicit word limit. Many, however, are in the 150-word to 250-word range.



Overview

1. Types of Supplements & How To Answer Them
 - 'Why Us'
 - 'Why Major' (including Brown's Open Curriculum question)
 - Extra-curricular Activity Essay
 - Community/ Perspective Essays
 - Civic engagement essay (Columbia, Princeton, Tufts)
 - Short Takes
 - Reverse-Why Essays (essays that ask how you will contribute to the school community)
 - Miscellaneous essays (unique prompts, longer essays)



2. Open Analysis Session where we look at examples of these essays.





Types of Supplementary Essays

1. 'Why Us?'

How to show a school that you truly want them

Other parts of your application give a sense of how you might contribute to (insert your desired school). But we also want to consider how (insert your desired school) will contribute to your interests and goals. Help us understand what aspects of (insert your desired school) appeal to you most, and how you'll make use of specific resources and opportunities here. (around 250 words)

Schools want to know why you'd like to attend, and how you'd be a match for them. They want to know how you'd take advantage of their resources and contribute to their community.

This essay is a great place to show that.



Writing this essay will require extensive research on your part, so that you can pick out unique parts of the school that appeal to you.

Use Resources for finding out information about schools (especially school websites)



They can come in different forms, e.g:

1. Please share with us why you consider Duke a good match for you. Is there something in particular about Duke's academic or other offerings that attract you? (200 words)
2. Why would you like to attend Brandeis? (250 words)
3. While arguing a Dartmouth-related case before the U.S. Supreme Court in 1818, Daniel Webster, Class of 1801, delivered this memorable line: "It is, Sir...a small college. And yet, there are those who love it!" As you seek admission to the Class of 2024, what aspects of the College's program, community or campus environment attract your interest? (100 words)



How to write the 'why us' essay

- Keep in mind who 'Us' is.
- Are your values and the values of the school in synchrony?

E.g if one of the key values of school xyz is collaboration, mention that you are a good collaborator. Explain how maybe you've worked with a team in a certain project. (support)

- Have a thesis - Would be great to mention your career goals

e.g. 'by majoring in engineering, I will be able to be a skilled/promising engineer. Xyz will offer the opportunity to develop the skills I need in solid mechanics, structures, etc.....'

and be very specific

E.g. instead of 'while the curriculum will teach me how to know about sports and business' you can write 'while the core curriculum will instruct me on the intricacies of the industry from finance and development to licensing and merchandising, a concentration in sports will further my understanding of defining the success of sport franchise.....'

- Show how you are going to be involved in the school

E.g. i will join the Chemistry council and connect with local students to mentor green chemistry projects for their schools to expand my chemistry work

and mention how what you've mentioned will help you

*E.g. i will join the Chemistry council and connect with local students to mentor green chemistry projects for their schools **to expand my chemistry work***

- Mention something that is unique to the school

e.g a certain program that is offered by the school, click deep in the website and fall in love with the school, tradition, club, professor



DOs and DONTs

DOs

- Find niche things about the school
- Focus on not only what you can do for the school but also what the school will do for you
- Be authentic
- Share all ways you've been engaged with the school
- Show excitement!



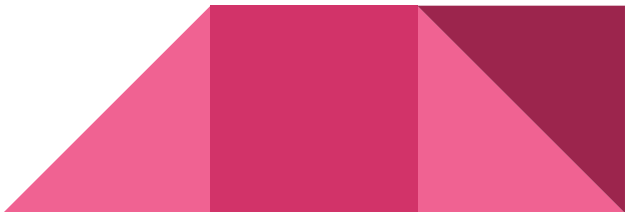
DONTs

- Quoting

It could be that the person reading your essay and evaluating your application actually wrote the words you're copying and pasting from the school website

- Writing like you have been accepted
- Writing about the school's size, location, reputation, weather, or ranking. Everyone else might be writing about this and you want to stand out
- Fill your essay with cliches
- Don't use emotion to describe why you want the school

E.g. I just feel like this is the school for me. The reader understand how are a good match for the school



In general, a 'Why School' essay should address two key questions:

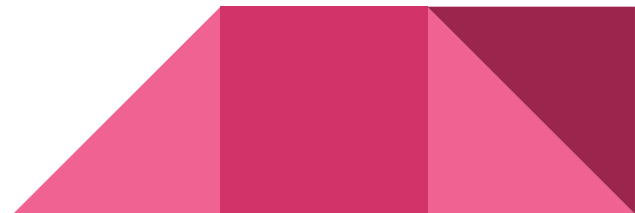
- 1) What qualities, resources, and attributes of the school are attractive to you?
- 2) What qualities and attributes do you possess that the school should care about? More specifically, why would a marriage of you and the school be a good idea for both parties?

Often times, applicants answering 'Why School' prompts thoroughly address the first of the aforementioned questions, but seriously lack or altogether miss answering the second. As you write your essay, be sure to think critically about both questions.



When answering the first question, the key to having a successful answer is to **include as many specific details as you can**. Specificity in this regard means naming professors, programs, majors, traditions, extracurricular activities, and other school-specific details. Your 'Why Northwestern' essay should **not** be casually interchangeable with your 'Why U-Penn' (or any other school's) essay. Rather, each 'Why School' essay should be uniquely marked and filled with content that is unique to that specific school.

The second question requires introspection and, consequently, is harder to offer general advice on. Think about your personal values, experiences, and goals; think about the highlights of your high school experience. What stands out? What kind of learner, thinker, and person are you? What kinds of activities do you enjoy? These are potentially difficult questions to answer as an 18-year-old, but thinking in this direction will help you address the second question



In essence, you are trying to explain to the Admissions Department why you would be a positive addition to their campus. It could be something as simple as: the school has many great initiatives about going green, and you are fervently passionate about researching renewable energy sources. You can then spend a good portion of say your 300 words discussing your passion for renewable energy.

Alternatively, you could identify a match on values: Northwestern for example celebrates interdisciplinary learning, and perhaps you are most enthralled in your studies when you have a varied course load across many subject areas. In that case, you could budget your 300 words describing examples from your high school experience that display your multifaceted learning style



“Why Major?”

What do you want to study, and why? How do you want to study your intended major at our institution?

Why are you drawn to your intended major and other areas of academic focus you wish to explore? (You may share a skill or concept that you found challenging and rewarding to learn, or any experiences beyond coursework that may have broadened your interest. (250 words)It's all about Match!!!

(i) Never use a long word where a short one will do.

(ii) If it is possible to cut a word out, always cut it out.

(ii) Never use the passive where you can use the active.

(iv) Never use a foreign phrase, a scientific word, or a jargon word if you can think of an everyday English equivalent.

(v) Break any of these rules sooner than say anything outright barbarous.

-excerpt from George Orwell, "Politics and the English Language", 1946.



Narrative -> point -> how it connects to you.



He held up the sheet of wrinkled paper, his eyes in silent protest.

The tattered bill requested 13,800 dollars for a three-day hospital stay.

“Why call the ambulance? Just leave me alone!” the frail old man muttered. Just a week ago, Mr. Vu suffered a stroke that required hospitalization. Because he could not understand English, Mr. Vu had not applied for health insurance, resulting in the exorbitant bill.

An internship at an Asian clinic opened my eyes to the untold story of limited-English proficiency patients, who often struggle to obtain health care in a maze of foreign forms and convoluted policies.

Suffering from a worsening stomach ache, Mrs. Wong was neglected in the county hospital for over two hours, unable to flag down a passing nurse for assistance because of the language barrier. Clutching a X-Ray order, Mr. Park searched in vain for Radiology in a blinding flurry of English letters.

Over the summer, these stories became too common – accounts of immigrants fighting for their right to care in a shockingly monolingual health system. After the internship, I participated in a medical interpretation training program and was licensed as a Mandarin health interpreter in November. I wanted to change the status quo.

My experiences this summer solidified my conviction of entering into public health, especially immigrant health, as my future course of study. America has long prided itself as a “melting pot” of cultures. Isn’t it only fitting that there exists equitable access to health care, regardless of the language spoken?

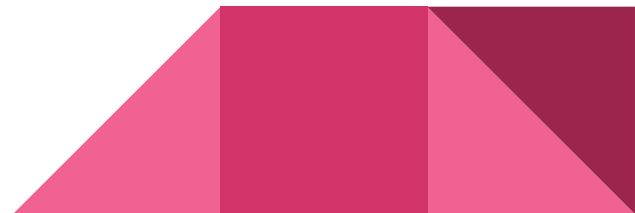


Here's the same essay, deliberately made worse (but to illustrate a very common problem in college application essays):

Last summer, I worked in an Asian clinic in Oakland, California. Over the course of the summer, I realized the plight of immigrants when it comes to obtaining equitable health care. In the modern health industry, immigrants and other residents who possess limited English proficiency are often overlooked because of their inability to communicate their symptoms to the doctor and complete paperwork in English. This problem is exacerbated when they cannot apply for health insurance, resulting in exorbitant health bills. In a country that claims to be the “melting pot” of cultures, this kind of neglect is no longer acceptable.

Many patients suffer extended waits in the hospital, unable to obtain assistance. It is possible that a worsening stomachache is the initial sign for appendicitis, which needs to be treated expeditiously. Often, hospital signs are also not translated into other languages, making navigation difficult for elderly patients. These scenes are played across hospitals in the nation everyday.

After my experiences this summer, I realized that I wanted to channel my energy into the revitalization of this system. It is no longer sufficient for us to stand on the sidelines and watch. To this end, I participated in a medical interpretation training program and was licensed as a Mandarin health interpreter. I hope I will be able to contribute my efforts to the field of public health, especially immigrant health, in the future. These patients cannot afford to passively wait for language-accessible care and continue to sacrifice their right to treatment.



Also 250 words, but this essay is riddled with problems, many of which Orwell pointed out in the blurb above.

1. The essay is filled with extraneous and needlessly difficult words. (“I wanted to channel my energy into the revitalization of this system”)
2. The essay lacks a personal voice – it’s very passive (“These scenes are played,” “immigrants are often overlooked,” “the problem is exacerbated”)
3. The essay never “shows” – it only “tells.”

Emphasis

This essay points out many problems of the healthcare system, but doesn’t offer any examples of the problems. At the end of the day, which essay will readers remember better? An essay that speaks in general terms or Mr. Vu with his bill?



Community/ Perspective Essays

Pretty Common. Can be tricky to answer and easy to mess up.
Closely tied with Civic Engagement Essay.

All an admissions' committee wants to see is GENUINE understanding and connection towards any community you're part of. Open your mind to different definitions of the term "community".

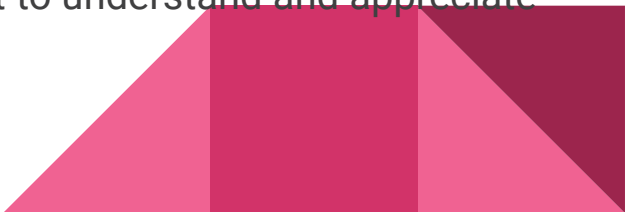
What comes to your mind when you think of community?



Community can mean: Neighbourhood, Church, Friend group, Tribe, Family, Band (for instrumentalists), Team (For athletes) etc. Basically *any space which you interact/ have interacted with regularly during your lifetime.*

Regardless of the definition you choose to govern your essay(s), it's important to show that you're aware of your surroundings.

Examples

1. Tell us about a place or community you call home. How has it shaped your perspective? (250 words) - Brown University.
 2. Duke University seeks a talented, engaged student body that embodies the wide range of human experience; we believe that the diversity of our students makes our community stronger. If you'd like to share a perspective you bring or experiences you've had to help us understand you better—perhaps related to a community you belong to, your sexual orientation or gender identity, or your family or cultural background—we encourage you to do so. Real people are reading your application, and we want to do our best to understand and appreciate the real people applying to Duke. (250 words)
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3. Describe the world you come from; for example, your family, clubs, school, community, city, or town. How has that world shaped your dreams and aspirations? (200-250 words) - Massachusetts Institute of Technology

4. Swarthmore students' worldviews are often forged by their prior experiences and exposure to ideas and values. Our students are often mentored, supported, and developed by their immediate context—in their neighborhoods, communities of faith, families, and classrooms. Reflect on what elements of your home, school, or community have shaped you or positively impacted you. How have you grown or changed because of the influence of your community? (250 words) - Swarthmore



Civic Engagement Essay

Closely tied to community essays. Schools want to see that you're getting involved in improving your community.



They're slightly different to community/ perspective essays in that those essays require you to describe how your community has influenced you; these essays require you to describe how you've impacted your community. DON'T CONFUSE THE TWO, EVEN IF THEY LOOK SIMILAR!!!

Regardless, the same principles apply. Show a connection with your community, and a meaningful engagement with your surroundings.



Examples

1. Columbia students take an active role in improving their community, whether in their residence hall, classes or throughout New York City. Their actions, small or large, work to positively impact the lives of others. Share one contribution that you have made to your family, school, friend group or another community that surrounds you. (200 words or fewer)
2. Princeton has a longstanding commitment to service and civic engagement. Tell us how your story intersects (or will intersect) with these ideals. (350 words)
3. At MIT, we bring people together to better the lives of others. MIT students work to improve their communities in different ways, from tackling the world's biggest challenges to being a good friend. Describe one way in which you have contributed to your community, whether in your family, the classroom, your neighborhood, etc. (200-250 words)



4. Reflect on your engagement with a community to which you belong. How do you feel you have contributed to this community? (250 words) - Yale

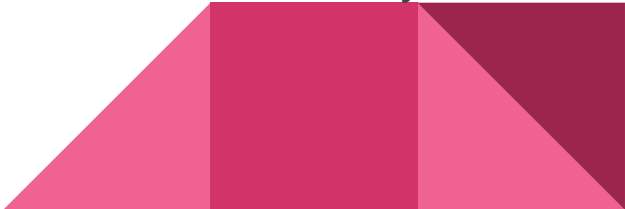
5. We live in an urban-global age with more than half of the planet's people living in cities. Trinity College is an urban liberal arts college deeply engaged with the local community and committed to making an impact across the world. How do you aspire to use your education to impact local and global communities? (250-650 words) - Trinity College

6. Where are you on your journey of engaging with or fighting for social justice? (200-250 words) - Tufts University



Tips for Writing

Writing these essays can take a three step approach:

- 1) Activity. From the activities list, pick one activity that is under community service and means a lot to you. Explain why engaging in that activity is important to you, and highlight the impact you had on your community through that activity.
 - 2) Relate that engagement with your civic environment to the school you're applying to. For example by mentioning a particular club that you may want to join and you think that through that club, you will be able to project the value you added to your previous community onto your new community (the school).
 - 3) After writing that bulk of the essay, remember to either highlight one of your values, be vulnerable, play the African Card, use your voice, or write creatively. These are bonuses for your essay.
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Extracurricular Activity or Work Experience

Briefly elaborate on an
extracurricular activity or work
experience of significance to you.
(250-500 words)

Tips For Writing

Pick one extracurricular activity that means a lot to you and simply write about it.

The point is to showcase your **values** and help the school see if you'd be a good fit.

As you can see, the more the essays you write, the more the avenues you get to express yourself and make a stronger case that you will fit into the school.

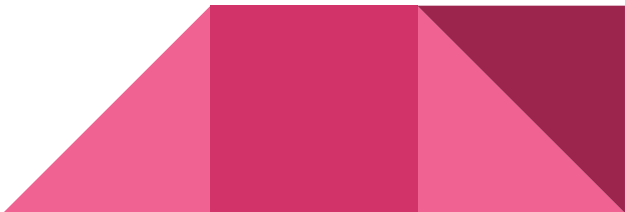
Therefore view the extra writing positively.



Short Takes

Straight to the point. No time to elaborate. These essays are the epitomes of conciseness. Prominent in Yale, Stanford & Princeton applications.



1. What inspires you? (35)
 2. The residential colleges at (School X) regularly host conversations with guests representing a wide range of experiences and accomplishments. What person, past or present, would you invite to speak? What question would you ask? (35)
 3. At (school X), most first-year students live in suites of four to six people. What do you hope to add to your suitemates' experience? What do you hope they will add to yours? (35)
 4. Students at school X embrace the concept of "and" rather than "or," pursuing arts and sciences, tradition and innovation, defined goals and surprising detours. What is an example of an "and" that you embrace? (35)
 5. What is the most significant challenge that society faces today? (50)
 6. Briefly elaborate on one of your extracurricular activities, a job you hold, or responsibilities you have for your family. (50)
 7. How have you spent the last two summers? (holidays) (50)
 8. What historical moment or event do you wish you could have witnessed? (50)
 9. What specific plan do you have, if any, for using the education you hope to receive? (50) - Harvard
 10. What is a new skill you would like to learn in college?(50)
 11. What song represents the soundtrack of your life at this moment? (50)
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12. What's the best piece of advice you've ever been given?

13. What's your favorite way to eat a potato?

14. You're relaxing on a Friday night. Suddenly, your favorite song pops into your head. What is it?



Tips For Writing Short Takes: (From College Essay Guy)

- 1) Make sure the reader finds something inside that's awesome and different from the window before.
 - 2) Answer "Why," even if the prompt doesn't ask you to. Do this because your core values may be hard to express in 1-2 words.
 - 3) DON'T MAKE THE SHORT REASON YOU PROVIDE (OR ANY OF YOUR ANSWERS) SUPER OBVIOUS. Example: I want to watch George Washington go shopping. I have an obsession with presidential trivia, and the ivory-gummed general is far and away my favorite. Great leaders aren't necessarily defined by their moments under pressure; sometimes tiny decisions are most telling--like knickers or pantaloons?
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4) Be specific. Examples: Documentaries. "Forks over Knives" made me go vegan; "Born into Brothels" inspired my Gold Award.

5) . DON'T FOR YOUR FAVORITE QUOTE, SAY SOMETHING THAT YOU'D FIND ON ONE OF THOSE "SUCCESS." Cheesy examples include: "Life is what you make of it." (or) "Dreams are X" (or) "Always follow your dreams"

6) DON'T USE TOP 50 ADJECTIVES ON THE "3-5 WORDS TO DESCRIBE YOU" QUESTION. These include responsible, adventurous, hardworking, etc. A good example, someone said Mulan.

There are 11 tips, research for the rest



Reverse-Why Prompts

Essays that ask “Why should we admit you?”

Schools want to know how you'll contribute to their academic community, their social and residential life etc. etc. How do you show this?

Sample Questions and Essays.

1. At Penn, learning and growth happen outside of the classroom, too. How will you explore the community at Penn? Consider how this community will help shape your perspective and identity, and how your identity and perspective will help shape this community. (150-200 words)
2. At Brown, you will learn as much from your peers outside the classroom as in academic spaces. How will you contribute to the Brown community? (250 words)
3. The process of discovery best advances when people from various backgrounds, experiences, and perspectives come together. How do you see yourself contributing to the diversity of Caltech's community? (Your response should range between 250-400 words.)
- 4.



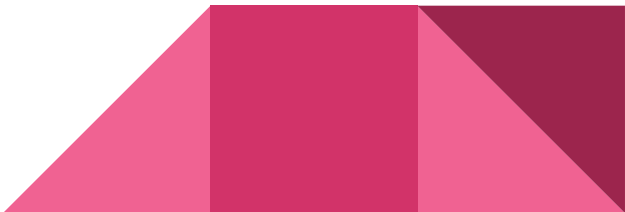
Unique Essay Questions/ Quirky Essays (Oddball Essays)

Essay prompts you won't find everywhere. These will make you think the most.

As long as you do a bit of reflection and introspective writing, you'll be fine.

These essays are immune to the copy-paste technique.

Examples

1. The infamous Stanford Roommate Essay: Virtually all of Stanford's undergraduates live on campus. Write a note to your future roommate that reveals something about you or that will help your roommate — and us — know you better. (100 to 250 words)
 2. The UChicago Prompts:
 - What if the moon were made of cheese? Or Neptune made of soap? Pick a celestial object, reimagine its material composition, and explore the implications. Feel free to explore the realms of physics, philosophy, fantasy...the sky is the limit!
 - What's so easy about pie?
 - In Homer's Iliad, Helen had a "face that launched a thousand ships." A millihelen, then, measures the beauty needed to launch one ship. The Sagan unit is used to denote any large quantity (in place of "billions and billions"). A New York Minute measures the period of time between a traffic light turning green and the cab behind you honking. Invent a new unit of measurement. How is it derived? How is it used? What are its equivalents?
 - It's said that history repeats itself. But what about other disciplines? Choose another field (chemistry, philosophy, etc.) and explain how it repeats itself.
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3. At Princeton, we value diverse perspectives and the ability to have respectful dialogue about difficult issues. Share a time when you had a conversation with a person or a group of people about a difficult topic. What insight did you gain, and how would you incorporate that knowledge into your thinking in the future? (300 words)

4.



Honorable Mention:

1. Longer essays that may require you to basically write another personal statement (see Harvard & Cornell)

Any
Questions

The
End